



WE CULTIVATE THE VIRTUE OF JUSTICE

ULPIAN THE JURIST (c. 170–223 CE)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Morality and theory of law

BEFORE

c. 450 BCE The Twelve Tables herald a millennium of codifying Roman law, ending with the *Code of Byzantine emperor Justinian I* in 529 CE.

27 BCE–14 CE Emperor Augustus appoints certain law experts, or jurists, to give legal opinions on his behalf.

1st century CE Two rival law schools flourish in Rome: the Sabinians tend to promote tradition and conservative orthodoxy, and the Proculians reasoning and consistency.

AFTER

533 CE Justinian I publishes the *Digest*, a compendium of writings of Roman jurists.

c. 1070 Manuscripts of Justinian's legal books are rediscovered in northern Italy, prompting a revival of interest in Roman law and in Ulpian.

Domitius Ulpianus was the most influential jurist of Classical Rome. He wrote prolifically, authoring over 200 books on law in little more than 10 years. His acclaim was renewed many centuries later in the Middle Ages, when the name “Ulpian” became synonymous with Roman law.

Distinguished career

Ulpian was born in the late 2nd century in the Phoenician city of Tyre, in what is now Lebanon. The nearby city of Berytus (Beirut) was home to the most famous law

school of the Roman Empire, and it is possible that Ulpian studied or taught there.

In Rome, Ulpian rose to be a high-ranking official in the imperial government. Early in the 3rd century, he served under Emperor Caracalla as his master of petitions, penning replies to requests made to the emperor. It was after 212 CE, when Caracalla extended citizenship to all free inhabitants of the empire, that Ulpian began to write his own works on law for the benefit of, among others, the new citizens. In 222 CE, the new emperor, Severus

Ulpian the Jurist states three maxims (principles) of law.

Live **honestly**
(*honeste vivere*).

Harm **no one**
(*alterum non laedere*).

Give everyone what is **due to them** (*sum cuique tribuere*).